The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Fire broke out at a crucial port in the **United Arab Emirates** after the second Iranian drone strike since Saturday. Operations had to be halted at Fujairah, the UAE's only oil-exporting port outside the **Strait of Hormuz**. Earlier, Donald Trump again demanded that other countries help open up the waterway and threatened consequences for NATO if allies did not assist America.

Germany's foreign minister said that he did not see NATO "assuming responsibility" for the shipping lane. **Britain's** prime minister said he was working with European leaders on finding ways to achieve a "swift resolution" to the crisis, but that doing so would not be a NATO mission. Sir Keir Starmer stressed that Britain "will not be drawn into a wider war" in Iran.

America's treasury secretary, Scott Bessent, said that any delay to a much-anticipated meeting between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping, his **Chinese** counterpart, would be only because of "logistics". Mr Trump suggested suspending the summit after saying China should also "help" reopen the Strait of Hormuz. China's only response so far has been to say it is "maintaining communication with all parties".

France's populist-right **National Rally** (RN) party made gains in the first round of municipal elections, putting it on track for its highest ever number of local councillors. The RN's candidates may perform less well in the second round, which takes place this coming weekend, if their opponents form alliances. The polls are a test for political parties ahead of next year's presidential election.

Israeli attacks killed at least 16 Palestinians in **Gaza** and the West Bank on Sunday, according to Palestinian health officials, one of the highest daily tolls in weeks. An air strike in Gaza killed nine police officers travelling in a vehicle. In the West Bank Israeli troops fired on a car, killing four members of a family. Israel's government said it was investigating the incident.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said his administration is willing to share its expertise in shooting down Iranian-made drones with Middle Eastern countries, but wants payment or technological support in return. Ukraine has sent teams to several countries to advise on air defences. Ukrainian forces have been intercepting such drones since Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022.

"One Battle After Another" won six awards at the **Oscars**, including Best Picture. Michael B. Jordan took home Best Actor for his performance as twin gangsters in "Sinners". Both films pack politics into rollercoaster stories. Jessie Buckley was named Best Actress for her role as William Shakespeare's wife in "Hamnet". "Mr Nobody Against Putin", which takes on patriotism and propaganda in Russia, won Best Documentary.

Figure of the day: 50%, the increase in the average size of illegal-waste sites in Britain in the decade to 2024. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Europe braces for another energy shock

Europe has recently overcome one energy crisis but now another is upon it. After Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 Europe began weaning itself off Russian fuel. It has replaced most of the Russian pipeline gas it was receiving with liquefied natural gas from America and the Middle East. Now the war in Iran is causing its price to soar. QatarEnergy, which makes a fifth of world's supply, has stopped production.

The European Union's energy ministers, who are meeting on Monday, have a choice of unpleasant alternatives: let high prices clobber their economies, restart coal-power stations or perhaps even reconsider the bloc's complete ban on imports of Russian gas, due to take effect next year. The crisis also adds urgency to the EU's push to modernise its electricity grids. The war strengthens the case for renewable energy, and for upgrading the infrastructure needed to distribute it. But that is a long-term solution. For now, Europe faces another painful energy squeeze.

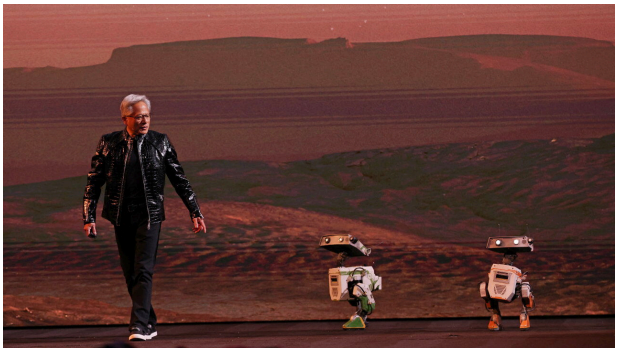
Photograph: Getty Images

Water could become a weapon in the Iran war

America's war against Iran, now in its third week, has caused the "largest supply disruption in history" to global oil markets, according to the International Energy Agency. For countries in the region, the threat to water supplies is as alarming.

Climate change has strained water resources across the arid Gulf: Qatar desalinates 99% of its drinking water; the United Arab Emirates roughly half. Iranian drones are capable of reaching the 400-plus desalination plants dotted along the Gulf coast.

Targeting such facilities is a war crime; Iran says that America did just that on March 7th. Bahrain claims that Iran hit one of its plants on the following day. Iran converts much less seawater than its neighbours, but may be more at risk: because of decades of poor management and an unprecedented drought Tehran, the capital, nearly ran dry last November.



Photograph: Getty Images

Nvidia defends its lead in the AI race

Nvidia's annual developer conference starts on Monday. The world's most valuable company is expected to unveil a chip designed specifically for "inference", the stage when artificial-intelligence models respond to users' queries. Until now AI firms have used Nvidia's graphics processors both to train models and to answer questions. Nvidia's development of a dedicated inference chip suggests that it now sees a growing market for specialised hardware.

The conference comes at a delicate moment. Investors are beginning to question how long the AI boom will last. On February 25th Nvidia reported record profits for the three months to January 25th, and forecast strong growth, yet its share price fell by more than 5% the next day. The company is also facing competition from its own customers. Large technology firms, including Google, Amazon and OpenAI, are developing their own AI chips to reduce their reliance on Nvidia. Jensen Huang, the firm's boss, will use his speech to reassure investors that Nvidia can stay ahead.

Photograph: Turkish Ministry of National Defence/AFP via Getty Images

Iran tests Turkey's patience

Turkey's government has opposed America's and Israel's war on Iran and has made clear it wants no part in it. Analysts have also assumed that Iran had no wish to draw in Turkey—a regional rival and a NATO member.

That assumption is being tested. Iran appears to have targeted NATO facilities inside Turkey. NATO defenses have already shot down three missiles headed for the country's airspace. The latest, on March 13th, was downed near the Incirlik airbase, which hosts Turkish, American and other NATO troops, judging by reports of sirens and explosions nearby. Iran has denied responsibility for the launches, but Turkey's foreign minister, Hakan Fidan, said that "technical data" contradict that claim. Turkey still wants to stay out of the war. But further attacks could force it to respond.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

There is always a third possibility, as long as you have the ability to find it.

Selma Lagerlöf